Debugging Rails Applications

This guide introduces techniques for debugging Ruby on Rails applications.

1 View Helpers for Debugging

One common task is to inspect the contents of a variable. In Rails, you can do this with three methods:

- `debug`
- `to_yaml`
- `inspect`

1.1 `debug`

The `debug` helper will return a <pre> tag that renders the object using the YAML format. This will generate human-readable data from any object. For example, if you have this code in a view:

```
<%= debug @article %>
<p>
  <b>Title:</b>
  <%= @article.title %>
</p>
```

You'll see something like this:

```
--- !ruby/object Article
attributes:
  updated_at: 2008-09-05 22:55:47
  body: It's a very helpful guide for debugging your Rails app.
  title: Rails debugging guide
  published: t
  id: "1"
  created_at: 2008-09-05 22:55:47
attributes_cache: {}


Title: Rails debugging guide
```

1.2 `to_yaml`

Displaying an instance variable, or any other object or method, in YAML format can be achieved this way:

```
<%= simple_format @article.to_yaml %>
<p>
  <b>Title:</b>
  <%= @article.title %>
</p>
```

The `to_yaml` method converts the method to YAML format leaving it more readable, and then the `simple_format` helper is used to render each line as in the console. This is how `debug` method does its magic.

As a result of this, you will have something like this in your view:

```
--- !ruby/object Article
attributes:
updated_at: 2008-09-05 22:55:47
body: It's a very helpful guide for debugging your Rails app.
title: Rails debugging guide
published: t
```